Instructor Guide: Slide Rebuild

Type: Hands-on lab (individual work) **Time:** 20 minutes (15 min individual work + 5 min debrief)

Pre-Activity Setup

- Prepare the "bad slide" and distribute it as a `.pptx` file via shared drive or learning-management download. The slide should literally embody the Scenario in the student file: title "Results." (with the period), eleven bullet points at 12pt, three different fonts, a 160×100-pixel chart screenshot, inconsistent indentation, and an oversized logo. Resist the temptation to "clean it up a little" before handing it out — the exaggerated badness is the teaching tool.
- Open a blank deck on your own laptop so you can follow along with any learner who gets stuck, particularly inside the Slide Master.
- Have a projector-ready "after" version of your own rebuild ready to show during debrief. The class sees their own work next to a reference rebuild; both are valid and the comparison drives the debrief.
- Confirm every learner has desktop PowerPoint. PowerPoint for the web does not expose the full Slide Master in the same way, which will derail step 2.

Facilitation Steps

1. **0:00 — Launch** (2 min): Project the bad slide. Ask the class to call out what is wrong with it. You will get at least six items (no title, too much text, multiple fonts, unreadable chart, inconsistent bullets, logo competing with title) in under a minute. Do not dwell — turn it into the prompt: "Rebuild this into one or two slides that carry the real takeaway." Start the timer.

2. **0:02 — Circulation, first 5 minutes** (focus: steps 1-2): Watch for learners who skip the written-takeaway step and jump straight to PowerPoint. Stop them: "Write the sentence on paper first. If the sentence does not land, the slide will not either." Also watch for learners who open the Slide Master but do not actually change anything — they are treating it as decoration, not enforcement. Have them set at least the title font and an accent color before they leave master view.

3. **0:07 — Circulation, middle 5 minutes** (focus: steps 3-5): The most common pattern here is cosmetic-only editing — learners delete a few bullets, shrink the font, and declare victory. Push for structural edits. Ask each learner to read you the takeaway sentence before they continue; if they hesitate, the slide is still too dense.
4. **0:12 — Circulation, last 3 minutes** (focus: steps 6-8): Alignment and the Layout verification step. Many learners will have title text that is visually centered but technically left-edged to a different anchor than the body. **Arrange → Align** fixes it in two clicks. Also verify that every slide has a named layout applied (step 7) — it is the habit that the rest of the course depends on.
5. **0:15 — Stop hands** (debrief, 5 min): Project two or three strong rebuilds and one learner's instructor-permitted "before and after" comparison. Run the debrief prompts below. Close with the connection to Lesson 4: "The deck you build in the capstone is this rebuild discipline applied five times in a row."

What to Circulate For

- **Cosmetic-only edits.** The single most common failure mode. The learner deletes three bullets, shrinks the font to 14pt, and keeps everything else. Recognize it by counting bullets — if the result still has eight, it is a cosmetic edit, not a rebuild. Name it aloud: "You edited the slide; you did not rebuild it. What is the one takeaway?"
- **No Slide Master discipline.** Some learners will skip step 2 entirely and format each slide directly. Ask them to open the Slide Master and verify the title font is set there, not on each slide. If the master is empty, have them set at least one font and close the master — it is the habit that carries forward.
- **Unreadable chart kept at unreadable size.** Shrinking a 160×100 chart to a slide-sized rectangle does not make it readable if the source image was low-resolution. If the learner kept the original image, have them either rebuild the chart as a shape or import a larger version.
- **Title that is still a noun.** "Incident review" or "Post-mortem" is not a sentence. If the title does not have a verb, it is not carrying a takeaway. Force the revision: "What happened and what does it mean? That sentence is your title."

- **Using two different layouts on two slides unintentionally.** If the rebuild is two slides, both should use named layouts (Title Only + Title + Content is fine; Blank + Title is not). The point of layouts is consistency across the pair.

Common Pitfalls

- **"But there really are eleven important things."** A common pushback from learners who have been handed a dense slide. Response: "Then you need eleven slides, or a handout. Not eleven bullets on one slide. Which is it?" Usually this surfaces that eight of the eleven bullets are methodology or speculation, not findings — they belong in speaker notes or an appendix.
- **Moving the chart but keeping all the bullets.** The learner makes the chart bigger but leaves the wall of text below it. The chart is now readable but the slide still has broken hierarchy. Push for the next cut.
- **"I cannot find the Slide Master."** On PowerPoint for Mac and Windows, **View → Slide Master**. If the learner is in PowerPoint for the web, the Slide Master is not exposed; have them switch to the desktop version if possible, or proceed with per-slide formatting and note the limitation for the debrief.
- **Alignment "looks fine" without using Arrange → Align.** Eyeballing alignment is the single most-common visual-polish failure. Watch for shapes that are "close" — Arrange → Align Top with two shapes selected is five seconds and catches it.
- **Save as `.pptx`.** Some learners autosave to `.ppt` (the older format), which drops theme fidelity. Not a huge deal for this lab but worth correcting as a habit.

Debrief Prompts

- **"What was the main takeaway in one sentence?"** Go around the room quickly. Every learner should be able to answer immediately. If they hesitate, their slide is probably still too dense — and that is the teaching moment. Name the hesitation; invite a revision.
- **"If someone saw your slide for three seconds with no voice-over, what would they walk away knowing?"** Compare to the original. The three-second test almost always fails on the original and passes on the rebuild. Naming the contrast out loud is what locks in the design discipline.

- **"What moved to speaker notes? Why is that the right place for it?"** Draws out the distinction that slides are for the audience; speaker notes are for the presenter; appendices are for readers who want the full detail later. Three different channels, three different purposes.

Expected Answers

A reference rebuild will have:

Element	Expected value
Slide count	1 (strong) or 2 (acceptable). Three or more signals that something was not cut.
Title style	Sentence case; contains a verb; names the finding. Example: "Runbook gap extended Mean Time To Resolve (MTTR) on the April 7 incident to 112 minutes."
Dominant visual	One chart or one shape-based diagram per slide, sized to read from the back of the room.
Bullet count total	0 on a strong one-slide rebuild; up to 3 on a two-slide rebuild.
Layout	Title Only or Title + Content, applied via Home → Layout. Blank layouts with free-form content are a red flag.
Slide Master	Title font and accent color set on the master, not on individual slides.
Speaker notes	Full-sentence narrative for anything the presenter will say.
Appendix	Methodology, raw data, and detail notes relocated off the main slides.

If a learner produced a rebuild that breaks one of these expectations but defends the choice convincingly (for example, "I used a Title Only layout with no visual because the sentence itself is the finding"), that is acceptable. The goal is defensible design, not uniform output.